made of what one would think of as the highlight of Valmiki's *Ramayana*, which is the kidnapping of Rama's wife Sita by the demon Ravana and her subsequent rescue from the island of Lanka with the aid of the monkey warrior Hanuman and his army of monkeys.

Nevertheless, at the core of most versions are the events which helped to inspire Valmiki and others with the concept of an epic battle between good and evil: a sea-borne military expedition from Bengal that went all the way south as far as the island of Lanka, leading to conflict with one or more local rulers and ending in an alliance with the local king – an invasion that is unlikely to have taken place before the fifth century BCE.

The first English translation of Valmiki's *Ramayana* was made by two missionaries very much in the same mould as Robert Caldwell, William Carey and Joshua Marshman. It was printed at their Baptist Mission Press in Serampore between 1806 and 1808 as part of the declared objective of the Orientalist movement in Bengal not only to study India 'in all its aspects' but also to make India's culture accessible to all. So the *Ramayana* became the first of a series of publications of Sanskrit classics funded by the subscriptions of members of the Asiatic Society of Bengal and the College of Fort William in Calcutta, 'being desirous of promoting the knowledge of the Literature of India, and, at the same time, of disclosing to the Learned of Europe the stores which lie hid in the Ancient Languages of India'.[7]

That first English version of the *Ramayana* makes for heavy reading today and has been superseded by far better translations by modern Indian scholars. However, I have to admit to still having a soft spot for the version published in rhyming couplets in the 1870s by … who else but my hero Ralph Griffith, written in his retirement in the Nilgiri Hills. In the following excerpt Rama's ally, King Sugriva, orders an army of 'ten thousand of our race' to cross the Vindhyas and